of the manpower for the insurgency. Second, Muslims in Rajouri and Poonch suffered greatly during previous India-Pakistani conflicts, which made them wary of retribution from the Indian army. Third, the militants simply passed through Rajouri and Poonch after crossing the LoC because the high-priority areas originally were in the Valley.[42] HuA militants were not ethno-linguistically suited to operating in these areas and indigenous militants from these regions were unwilling to target Hindus civilians. Lashkar cadres, on the other hand, enthusiastically took to massacring non-Muslims. The group's recruitment patterns meant that many of its members shared the same ethnolinguistic characteristics as those in Rajouri and Poonch.[43] Lashkar's composition also matched that of the army, as the two recruited from similar areas in Pakistan. The army and ISI believed, correctly, that this would make the group easier to control. So too would the fact that it was an Ahl-e-Hadith outfit and lacked the type of infrastructure in Pakistan that HuA enjoyed.

Lashkar militants had been active in Indian-administered Kashmir since 1990, according to a report compiled by the group chronicling its activities there.[44] They often cooperated with other groups on operations during the early 1990s and at times served in a support capacity. Lashkar launched its first official operation in 1993 and increased its presence over the next several years; though it was in the latter years of the decade that its activities really accelerated. At one of the group's annual congregations, known as Ijtemas, its operational commander Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi claimed Lashkar militants had been 'engaged properly and striving hard' against Indian forces since 1995.[45] This aligns with the time period when state support for the group was increasing. By then a 'superficial normalcy' was returning to the urban areas. As the insurgency shifted to Rajouri and Poonch as well as remote areas of the Valley and Doda, Lashkar began paying greater attention to these regions.[46]

Having witnessed close to seven years of conflict, supporters of armed conflict in the Valley were plagued by 'exhaustion and loss of morale.' New Delhi moved to take advantage of this and complete its pacification campaign through continued repression combined with the reinstallation of a civilian government.[47] Elections for the State Legislature were held in September 1996 for the first time since the flawed 1987 round sparked the conflict. In addition to conflict fatigue and an increasingly sophisticated